

Emotional Habits

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Project 3

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The motivation for this project came from the idea of creating a game related to the human brain and neurological interactions. Initially, I wanted to explore a game that used the brain as a central concept, but later I decided to focus on developing a simple interface that creates a narrative experience with the user. The main idea of the project is a narrative game that interacts with the user through questions. The user will have a character that represents themselves in the form of a shadow figure. This shadow character needs to be taken care of, which is where the concept of the semester came in. The character must pass the semester, but it's not only about the grades they receive, it's mostly about their mental and emotional state. They need to maintain good mental and physical health. This will be reflected through a series of questions that the user answers to evaluate their state. Depending on the decision that are taking, the character's heart and brain levels will be affected or improved in a displayed visual marker system. Additionally, the character will move around the canvas in a way that resembles real-time animation of the user moving through their daily life. I wanted to give this shadow a sense of life, so I added eyes and a mouth to give it more characteristic features and personality. Color will play an important role in representing the user's state throughout the experience. The background color will change dynamically in response to the user's answers, providing immediate visual feedback about the character's mental and emotional state. For example, warmer colors might represent positive states like calm or happiness, while cooler or darker colors could indicate stress, anxiety, or declining mental health. This color-shifting system creates an ambient atmosphere that reinforces the character's current condition and helps the user understand their progress.

The game will be structured across multiple weeks, reflecting in a typical academic semester. Each week will present new questions that the user must navigate. The choices made during each week will accumulate and directly impact the character's overall progress and well-being. As the semester advances, the difficulty and intensity of the questions may increase to reflect the pressure students often experience. At the end of the game, the user will either pass or fail based on the cumulative health both mental and physical, that they've maintained throughout the semester. This outcome emphasizes that success isn't just about completing assignments, but about sustaining balance and self-care. There will be a comment box feature that allows users to share their thoughts about the experience. Users can write about what resonated with them, suggest improvements, or share personal reflections that might help others. These comments will be displayed in a collective visualization, creating a shared space where players can see they're not alone in their experience. This community aspect adds depth to the project by transforming it from a solitary experience into a collective conversation about mental health and student well-being.

The questions will be generated using artificial intelligence to create variety and ensure there are enough diverse prompts to keep the experience engaging throughout multiple weeks. Using AI allows for larger and thoughtful questions that address different aspects of student life: academic pressure, social connections, sleep habits, self-care practices, and emotional well-being. This approach ensures that each playthrough feels connected and that the questions remain contextually appropriate to the challenges students face during a semester. The main intention behind this project came from my personal struggles with time management and well-being during university. University life can be challenging for many people, and this semester was particularly difficult for me. I often struggled with making decisions that affected my physical health and mental state. Sometimes it feels nearly impossible to find space to take a break from academic demands and other responsibilities to take care of myself. The constant pressure to perform, meet deadlines, and balance multiple commitments can leave little room for self-reflection and self-care.

That's why I wanted to create a visualization that have an emotional connection with a character that reflects myself and the decisions I make throughout the semester. By externalizing these experiences through the shadow character, I hoped to create a tool for self-awareness, a way to see the consequences of my choices in real-time and understand how they impact my overall well-being. This project is both personal and a resource for others who face similar challenges. It's about recognizing that our daily choices matter and that taking care of ourselves is essential to success on demanding academic environments. The main reference for this project came from the types of exams commonly given to students. Throughout my academic experience, I've many countless multiple-choice exams with "choose the correct answer" format. I wanted to take this familiar structure and build it into something more meaningful transforming it from a tool for academic assessment into a tool for personal reflection and self-assessment. Instead of testing knowledge, these questions test awareness of one's own mental and physical state, making the user think critically about their habits, choices, and priorities. The expected outcome of this project is to create an understandable narrative game experience where users can input their information in an interactive way while engaging in something positive and reflecting on decisions made throughout the semester. I also aim to make this a fun experience that incorporates data visualization shared community reflection for the semester. My goal is to provide users with a good interface that functions in a dynamic way.